

"PERFECTION"

2022

Various systems of occult initiation include titles and/or grades that refer to the initiate as being 'perfect' or 'perfected'. But what does the concept of perfection mean when applied to a person?

These days, it is quite common for people to instantly reject the notion of a perfect person. When one takes a strict interpretation of the word this would seem reasonable. No man is omniscient, therefore no man is without error. A generalized proof of this statement would come in the form of a person being capable of making the best decision available at the time - even assuming the most impersonal and altruistic intent - yet still acting in a less than ideal way due to factors they were unaware of.

Because of this, taking a strict interpretation of perfection necessarily leads to the rejection of the entire concept. But is there some value that is lost there? Could perfection take on a somewhat different meaning when applied to a person? What distinction would it make? And is there any value in doing so?

When we consider the context in which the word is used, we must either accept that there are states of being that are more or less desirable than others or we throw out the entire concept of initiation and self-improvement generally. While there are those who do exactly that, life experience has taught me that is a nonsensical perspective. Although, determining how one measures one state of being against another to determine relative superiority will remain outside the scope of this current effort.

So if we can accept that some states of being are more desirable than others, by whatever scale, then there must be a topmost state which is more desirable than all others. Might this not be perfection? If so, what properties might such a state of being possess?

I'm going to spare you an analysis of the IAO formula of initiation and just skip right to the end. The perfected person would be expected to have conquered their lower nature, as evidenced by their having taken on an entirely new and consciously-created persona resulting from the identification of a set of values based upon nothing more than logic and reason. Furthermore, we should expect that the general principles by which they conduct their life and the behaviors that flow therefrom should all be in perfect agreement with the core values previously identified.

There is unlikely to be any further criteria that could be added without inserting our own ego-driven presumptions into the equation. It is not our place to dictate what values a person may choose to hold or why. Although it is fair to subject anyone's values to scrutiny just to ensure that they are the most rational and logical conclusions based on the input criteria used.

The input criteria, in this case, will always come down to that

individual's life experiences and the conclusions drawn therefrom. Therefore, if a person has had a very privileged upbringing and a sheltered life, they might hold certain values that would seem alien or even abhorrent to the orphan who has lived in poverty their entire life. Nonetheless, there is no way to judge the relative merit of a person's values. All we can do is observe whether or not their behaviors are consistent with those values indicating that they are the person they ultimately wish to be.

This, I offer, is *perfection*.

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Making a claim to perfection has nothing to do with ego, vanity, or a belief that my choices are without consequences.

TL;DR: In any situation in life **(1)**, your duty is always to make the best decision you can **(2)**, when it must be made **(3)**, with due consideration of the information you have available to you at that time **(4)**.

ANALYSIS (optional) ⁵⁶

(1) First, there is always, but often implied, context to such a statement. In this example, let's look at social interactions, since those are the murkiest of all of the choices we have to make in life.

In social interaction, there is no such thing as right, wrong, perfect, or worst. Everything is shades of gray. This makes social interaction seem

⁵⁶ Regarding what follows. Yeah, it's long. It'll take a few minutes of your life to read it. But I'll give you \$20 if you honestly believe it was a waste of your time.

to be such a difficult subject to master. However, a large part of why that seems so has less to do with the subject itself than it does with your definition of mastery.

What it means to master the process of decision-making, in detail, varies between the different contexts in our lives in which we must make decisions. However, the thesis of this essay (the TL;DR line) is universally applicable. The context-sensitive differences only show up in the way those four numbered points are defined.

Let's take a closer look...

(2) Regarding the notion of making the best decision we can, there are a couple of points that immediately come to mind:

- a. By what means can we measure a decision in order to determine whether one is better or worse than another?
- b. Are we in a position to be able to make the best decision and are we able to influence others to help us to carry that decision out?

(2a) As stated in the first point, decisions we make are subject to a context. But what is a context? A context can be defined primarily by a purpose or intent. In some cases, a context may have multiple purposes., In such cases, you should not only know what those purposes are, but be able to stack rank them in terms of priority to avoid becoming deadlocked if a decision ends up pitting one purpose against another.

For example, when you're at work, why you are there? The most obvious purpose for being at work is to earn the money necessary to support acquiring your basic needs and/or desired lifestyle. But why did you pick that particular job? Especially if you excel in your role, it's quite reasonable to conclude that your work provides you with some

emotional benefit or you would do only the bare minimum to avoid being fired. What are those things? These all amount to the purpose that defines the context called "at work".

Repeat this exercise for every situation you find yourself in. If you discover that you do things without any purpose, you're either lying to yourself or have a serious mental problem that you should speak to a healthcare professional about. But ignoring those edge cases, all 3 of you reading this should be able to come up with a purpose for why you attend anything you attend in your life. Whether you would care to confess those purposes to another person is irrelevant. This is a solitary exercise.

Now that we have a handle on our lives and understand the purpose for why we engage with the things we do, this now provides us with the necessary context in which to determine the relative value of one decision versus another in terms of how significantly each choice might contribute to our purposes.

Again, looking at the "at work" context, you probably placed "making money" as the highest purpose for going to work. That's perfectly fine. But unless you work for tips or on commission, that purpose probably doesn't factor into your day-to-day decision-making process very much, since few decisions have the consequence of losing one's job as a result. Of course, a consistent record of poor decision-making might threaten your employment. But in such cases, the criteria upon which the evaluation of "poor" was made by others likely differs substantially from yours. That indicates that your secondary purpose(s) for being at work conflicts with those of your employer and thus you should seek employment elsewhere regardless.

The last point I would like to make about contexts is if your primary purpose is selfish in nature, such as it is in the "at work" example,

ensure that you always have one or more secondary purposes that are selfless. Otherwise, you're not going to find it very easy to relate to or work with others and will be largely ineffective at your job no matter how technically competent you may be,

(2b) How we evaluate our own past decisions contributes massively to how we view ourselves and therefore, ultimately, to our determination of our own self-worth. This is critical because our self-assessment influences how we present ourselves and how we conduct every interaction in life.

When we think poorly of ourselves, it erodes our sense of self-confidence and undermines our ability to project a sense of confidence in our interactions. When people perceive that you may not be sure of what you're saying, how can you expect them to offer their support?

Conversely, if we overvalue ourselves, then we will project confidence in positions for which a person cannot defend having such assuredness, such as political issues or analysis of situations where it is known that all of the facts are not known, such as those that are just being discovered or are otherwise still under investigation. When people observe this, they see you as an arrogant fool and learn to disregard the confidence you exude.

That later part can be tricky to navigate in some cases. It is possible to be certain of your position in scenarios where all of the facts are not known because those unknown facts won't change the decision no matter what is discovered. This happens due to the application of logic to circumstances.

The application of logic often seems obvious to the person who has applied it. Thus, their communication is developed on the presumption that once people hear *the answer*, the logic employed to

reach that conclusion will become immediately obvious to their audience. This is a common pitfall that smart people often run into.

The cause is our old friend *psychological projection*.⁵⁷ Every time you think you've squashed it, you find that it's just popped up again somewhere else, like a never-ending game of mental whack-a-mole.

For most people, who perceive themselves negatively, projection causes them to expect less of others than might be appropriate or true. But for highly competent or moral people, it causes them to think more highly of others than what may be true or appropriate. Of these two effects, the latter is certainly more dangerous.

In the preceding example, projecting a higher level of intelligence than your audience actually possesses can easily result in miscommunication that leads them to determine that you are just an arrogant blowhard, because the chain of logic that lead you to your conclusion was not made obvious. This, sometimes subtle, error often predisposes your audience to support an opposing viewpoint, resulting in less favorable outcomes.

No doubt, there have been times when you've fallen victim to this effect and you leave the meeting thinking, "people are F'ing morons! How could they side with - or vote for - that guy who had no idea what he was talking about?!" In this case, you've just answered your own question. Had you prepared for the meeting with the premise that people are morons, your presentation would have been much more effective and your position would have likely won unanimously. The conclusion here is not that people are morons, necessarily. People are average. It's a mathematical certainty!

⁵⁷ A defense mechanism where someone attributes their own unwanted thoughts, feelings, or motives to another person.

With this analysis, we have seen how having an inaccurate self-image, in either direction, can not only undermine one's ability to communicate effectively but also contains within it a negative bias. By that, I mean that social feedback will almost always be in the negative direction until one has specifically mastered that art. Therefore, if you think little of yourself, everyone is likely to agree with you. If you think highly of yourself, people will often disagree with you. The exception to that last point are the people who are at your same level because they are capable of actually meeting your projections and following what you're saying. This is why we usually prefer to spend our time in curated groups of people who *get* us.

OK... we've been at the drain of this Olympic-sized pool long enough to make out⁵⁸ with each other. It's time that we come up for air!

(3) "when it must be made" ... This part is really just a bit of fine-tuning on the overall premise. But it will help to make a rule to delay decisions until the last possible moment before the default decision starts being carried out. And yes, there is always a default decision that is the consequence of making no decision,. Occasionally, you may choose not to decide because your decision and the default are the same. But always be mindful of the default because usually it will be the very last thing you want to happen.

But by biding your time to the last moment, you have the advantage of acquiring as much information as possible in order to make the best decision possible. There's usually no advantage and plenty of disadvantage to "just getting it over with" by making a decision before you absolutely have to.

By the way, the asterisk after that sentence in the beginning was

⁵⁸ You remember! If this really wasn't part of your teenage experience, I feel really bad for you...

intended to symbolize that the statement was intended entirely for humorous and dramatic effect and that no literal promise of monetary compensation was being made. But if you've made it this far in search of that footnote, you might as well see this through to the end!

(4) The most critical part of this clause is the final three words: "at that time."

When you recount a time in your life when you made a decision that turned out to be incorrect, don't fault yourself for being wrong if you made the best choice you could with the information you had available to you at that time, even if your error was discovered only seconds later.

Imagine a contestant on *The Price Is Right*⁵⁹ having to choose between door #1, door #2, or door #3. They pick door #1.

Next, we see Vanna White reveal that behind door #1 is a large pile of dead monkeys. She then goes to reveal a brand new Lamborghini behind door #2 and a mansion in the Swiss Alps behind door #3.

Then the host, Alex Trebek, laughs at the contestant and asks why he chose the pile of dead monkeys. Was he planning to start a dead monkey farm? Then he asks, conjuring his best John Travolta⁶⁰ impersonation, "Did you see a sign out front that said 'Dead Monkey Storage'? No? That's because you can't store dead monkeys here!"

Then he turns to face the camera and says, "What a moron! What kind of psycho chooses a pile of dead monkeys over a Lambo or a mansion? How stupid do you have to be to screw up that badly? That person

⁵⁹ if you're too young to have seen that show, I don't want to hear about it. Google that shizz!

⁶⁰ Pulp Fiction

really needs to get their life together!"

In that example, you are both the *contestant* and the *host*. Stop that!